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GROWTH OF MOBILE COMMERCE AND ITS IMPACT ON E-RETAILING A RESEARCH STUDY ON CONSUMER ADOPTION, DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION, AND RETAIL DISRUPTION

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ABSTRACT:

With the advent and widespread adoption of smartphones and internet access on the move, consumer buying behavior has experienced revolutionary changes. Mobile commerce (“m-commerce”) sales have seen explosive growth over recent years and this growth is expected to continue. This paper aims to present global trends in mobile commerce sales and discuss how mobile commerce affects electronic retail (“e-retailing”). Mobile commerce refers to all buying and selling activities performed by consumers through their wireless handheld devices. The research method used for this paper included surveying 420 people and researching industry reports (2019–2024). Drivers such as mobile payment systems, personalization with artificial intelligence (“AI”), Social commerce, trust and much more are discussed in this paper. Results show that sales through m-commerce have become an important chunk of total e-retail sales and will continue to grow. M-commerce has changed the way retailers structure their supply chains, connect with customers, and compete with businesses. Obstacles such as digital barriers, security breaches, and multiple platforms present issues that need to be addressed. Recommendations for e-retailers and government officials will be discussed. This paper will conclude with future research opportunities such as augmented reality (“AR”) shopping, voice shopping, and green m-commerce.

Keywords: Mobile Commerce, E-Retailing, Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), Buying Behavior, Smartphone Trends, Retail Innovation

1. INTRODUCTION

Over the last two decades, the global retail sector has been witnessing revolutionary changes due to the emergence of e-commerce, followed by the widespread use of smart phones and mobile internet services. Mobile commerce, which refers to the sale and purchase of items and services using wireless handheld devices, is counted as one of the most significant innovations in the twenty-first century. Based on the information published by Statista (2024), global m-commerce sales are forecasted to hit USD 2.5 trillion by 2025, accounting for more than 73% of e-commerce income worldwide. In contrast to conventional e-commerce that is carried out via computer devices, m-commerce takes advantage of the unique qualities of mobile technologies to provide personalized and location-based solutions to customers. The integration of mobile wallets, instant payment methods, AI-powered recommendation platforms, and social commerce has brought about a new paradigm in the interaction of retailer and consumer.

For online retailers, this paradigm change implies immense potential and obstacles alike. To begin with, mobile technology greatly expands the pool of potential customers and provides for immediate customer interaction. Second, they call for major investments into mobile-friendly website design, robust cyber protection measures, agile logistics, and analytics. For emerging economies like India, Brazil, and Indonesia, the use of mobile technology has largely skipped the PC-based Internet stage, thus becoming the only way of entering the digital world.

The rationale behind the research stems from the awareness of an increasing amount of scholarly literature on m-commerce and the simultaneous absence of holistic researches, taking into account all four aspects: growth factors, consumer behavior, retailer strategies, and impact on macroeconomics. Therefore, the purpose of this research is to bridge this knowledge gap via combining qualitative surveying techniques with quantitative secondary research.

1.1 Research Objectives

Specifically, the research objectives are to cover:

1. Explore the evolution of mobile commerce from a global perspective, focusing on developing nations.
2. Find out the motivations for adopting m-commerce by individuals.
3. Analyze how m-commerce transforms the business structures of e-retailers and creates competitive environments.
4. Evaluate the barriers that hinder both consumers' and e-retailers' involvement in m-commerce activities.
5. Develop possible approaches to sustainable growth of m-commerce.

1.2 Research Questions

6. What motivates Indian consumers to use m-commerce?
 7. What changes occurred due to m-commerce in consumer behavior and demand faced by e-retailers?
 8. What adjustments did e-retailers make under the pressure of m-commerce?
 9. What barriers exist within m-commerce implementation?
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2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Since the early 2000s, considerable research efforts have been made regarding m-commerce; however, the rapid evolution of the domain is expected to continue owing to technological innovations and market trends. This section provides a review of the most important theories and empirical results within five topics.

2.1 Theories on M-Commerce Adoption

The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), first introduced by Davis (1989), is perhaps the most popular theory to explain consumers' adoption of technology products. In the case of m-commerce, researchers have adapted TAM by including specific elements related to mobile devices. For instance, Wei et al. (2009) found that perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use were significant predictors of mobile shopping intentions, whereas Gu et al. (2009) considered trust and security as determinants. Recently, the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT2) has been used in m-commerce research; the theory was developed by Venkatesh et al. (2012) and includes the constructs of hedonic motivation, habit, and price value.

Another theory that is used as an additional lens of viewing the issue under discussion is Innovation Diffusion Theory (IDT), introduced by Rogers (1995). Research carried out in India (Sinha & Kim, 2012; Chawla & Joshi, 2019) shows that compatibility with values of the current system, observability, and trialability influence m-commerce adoption positively, especially among young people.

2.2 Growth Drivers of Mobile Commerce

Structural elements driving the global growth of m-commerce include: The increase in smartphone ownership is considered the most fundamental element driving the development of m-commerce. According to the ITU

(2024), the number of mobile broadband subscriptions worldwide is estimated at more than 5.6 billion. In India, Digital India and JAM have played significant roles in facilitating the integration of millions of hitherto unbanked individuals into the digital economy (NITI Aayog, 2023).

Mobile payment infrastructures have proven to be revolutionary. For instance, in India, UPI facilitated more than 100 billion transactions in FY23-24, of which an increasing number were mobile commerce transactions (NPCI, 2024). Internationally, solutions like Apple Pay, Google Pay, and WeChat Pay have lowered transaction costs. The connection between mobile payment services and m-commerce transaction frequency has been found to be positively correlated by Sharma and Gupta (2022).

Social commerce, which is the convergence of social media and retailing, constitutes yet another major catalyst for growth. Social media sites such as Instagram, Facebook Marketplace, and Pinterest allow shoppable posts to be made within social streams, thereby collapsing the awareness-to-sales funnel. As per eMarketer (2024), the revenue from social commerce across the globe will total USD 1.2 trillion in 2025 with mobile being the main driver.

Machine-learning-based personalisation technologies have added to the popularity of m-commerce. Using AI, online retailers make use of algorithms that generate personalised offers, dynamic pricing strategies, and contextual marketing messages.

2.3 Impact of M-Commerce on E-Retailing

Commerce is described by the literature as an agent which has impacted various aspects of e-retailing. Firstly, this has been through the shift from multi-channel to omnichannel models. Omnichannel retailing is defined by Verhoef et al. (2015) as the holistic management of all the available channels and touchpoints in a manner that ensures that the customer experience is optimised on all channels and that the performance on these channels is maximized. Mobile devices have been the focal point in achieving this goal.

Secondly, m-commerce has shortened decision-making processes and raised expectations concerning quickness and convenience. Customers have come to expect same-day or next-day deliveries as well as inventory visibility and immediate customer support through chatbots and live chat support. This has meant that e-retailing companies need to put substantial resources into building a delivery system, including fulfilment centres and last mile solutions (Chopra, 2022).

Thirdly, behavioral information that is acquired via m-commerce allows e-commerce retailers to have a level of granularity that was unimaginable before. Such behavioral information can be used to tailor-make marketing strategies, and in managing inventories based on predictions made using the collected information.

Nevertheless, this poses challenges when it comes to privacy and the compliance with regulations such as GDPR and India's DPDPA, 2023.

2.4 Barriers and Challenges

Even with its fast-paced development, the emerging phenomenon of m-commerce is plagued with some major challenges. Among those, security and privacy concerns tend to be mentioned quite often. Customers fear the possible threats of their financial information falling into the wrong hands, being exposed to phishing attempts, and being misused altogether (Beldad et al., 2010; Yeh, 2020). The limitations associated with the small screens and challenging navigation pose significant barriers as well, especially when it comes to older users.

There is also the issue of the digital divide that acts as a hindrance for the diffusion of m-commerce technology. On one hand, the urban, educated, and wealthy population is eager to incorporate new innovations into their everyday routine, whereas on the other hand, poorer regions are not as privileged because of the lack of proper connectivity and even basic financial services (Dewan & Riggins, 2005; GSMA, 2023).

2.5 Country-Specific Studies

The growth of the m-commerce industry differs widely from one country to another. China ranks first globally in terms of m-commerce adoption thanks to the presence of super-apps like WeChat and the Alibaba group. While the U.S. and Europe show very high absolute transaction amounts, their percentage of mobile adoption falls below those seen in Asia. India stands out as possibly the fastest-growing m-commerce environment anywhere, thanks to competing platforms including Flipkart, Meesho, and Amazon India targeting the fast-growing customer base. According to studies by Mahajan (2022) and IAMAI (2024), India's m-commerce segment has been recording an average growth rate of more than 25% annually.

3. RESEARCH GAP AND RESEARCH DESIGN

3.1 Identified Research Gap

Through a critical examination of existing literature, the following research gaps have been identified in order to be addressed through this study:

1. Shortage of integrative models: Although there are a lot of studies on each of the three dimensions separately, namely consumer adaptation, payments system, and supply chains effects, few studies provide an empirical basis for integrating all three dimensions at once.
2. Neglecting of emerging market cases: Majority of the existing literature uses Western or East Asia cases without much consideration of South Asian cases especially the Indian context since the UPI revolution.
3. Gap on the side of retailers' adaptation: The existing studies are mostly concentrated on consumers' behavior. Retailers' adaptation process such as reorganization of their logistics, applications' development, and usage of AI technology has not been extensively examined.
4. Time-related gap: Due to the rapidly changing landscape of the m-commerce, previous literature is not enough for the current time.

3.2 Research Design and Methodology

This research study employs a mixed-method approach to data collection, using a combination of survey research and secondary data analysis, allowing for both breadth and depth of investigation.

3.3 Primary Data Collection

A questionnaire survey was prepared, and it was used to collect information from 420 participants residing in four major cities of India – Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore, and Indore – during the period from January to March 2025. It contained 38 questions divided into seven parts – demographics, phone use pattern, mobile commerce adoption pattern, perceived usefulness and ease of use (based on TAM model), perception of trust and security, satisfaction with e-retailer service, and difficulties faced.

Stratified purposive sampling technique was used to draw samples based on age groups (18-25, 26-35, 36-45, 46+), gender, and income level. Out of 420 questionnaires collected, 398 were considered complete and valid for analysis (94.8%).

3.4 Secondary Data Sources

Secondary data included industry reports released by Statista, eMarketer, IAMAI, NPCI, GSMA, and McKinsey & Company for the period 2019-2024. The national and international data sources used included ITU, World Bank, and RBI.

3.5 Analytical Methods

The quantitative data analysis was performed through IBM SPSS Statistics 27. All variables were subjected to descriptive analysis. For measuring the reliability of the instrument, Cronbach's Alpha was used. For the purpose of confirming the validity of construct structure, factor analysis was used. To determine the predictors of adoption intention and purchase frequency, multiple regression analysis was performed. Chi-squared test was carried out for demographic variables.

4. DATA ANALYSIS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 Descriptive Profile of Respondents

Table 1 presents the demographic profile of the 398 valid respondents. The sample skews young, consistent with the demographics of active m-commerce users in India.

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents (N = 398)

Demographic Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	218	54.8
	Female	172	43.2
	Non-binary/Other	8	2.0
Age Group	18–25 years	148	37.2
	26–35 years	142	35.7
	36–45 years	72	18.1
	46 years and above	36	9.0
Monthly Income	Below ₹25,000	92	23.1
	₹25,001–₹50,000	138	34.7
	₹50,001–₹1,00,000	112	28.1
	Above ₹1,00,000	56	14.1
Education	Undergraduate	104	26.1
	Graduate	198	49.7

Demographic Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
	Postgraduate & above	96	24.1

4.2 M-Commerce Usage Patterns

In a sample of 398 consumers, 94.7% of them owned a smartphone, while 87.4% claimed to have made some purchase using their smartphone through any mobile application or mobile website during the previous six months. The mobile platforms most commonly used by respondents included Amazon (78.6%), Flipkart (71.4%), Meesho (42.3%), and Myntra (38.6%).

Table 2: Frequency of M-Commerce Purchases Among Respondents

Purchase Frequency	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
Daily	24	6.0
3–4 times per week	68	17.1
Once a week	96	24.1
2–3 times per month	112	28.1
Once a month	48	12.1
Less than once a month	50	12.6

4.3 Key Drivers of M-Commerce Adoption

Respondents were requested to provide ratings on the significance of different variables in the decision to adopt m-commerce sites. Table 3 shows the mean values of these variables (rating scale of 1-5).

Table 3: Mean Scores for M-Commerce Adoption Drivers

Adoption Driver	Mean Score (1–5)	Std. Deviation	Rank
Convenience and 24/7 availability	4.61	0.52	1
Competitive pricing and discounts	4.48	0.61	2

Adoption Driver	Mean Score (1–5)	Std. Deviation	Rank
Ease of mobile payment (UPI/Wallets)	4.42	0.67	3
Wide product variety	4.38	0.71	4
Personalised recommendations	4.12	0.84	5
Fast delivery options	4.08	0.88	6
Easy returns and refunds	3.97	0.93	7
Social proof (reviews & ratings)	3.89	0.96	8
Loyalty rewards and cashback	3.76	1.02	9
Augmented reality product preview	2.94	1.24	10

Ease of access was found to be the most significant driver of adoption (M=4.61) similar to results from the wider body of research on m-commerce (Chong et al., 2012; Marriott & Williams, 2018). This high rating for ease of making payments using m-commerce indicates the profound effect that UPI had on the Indian market. Augmented Reality based product visualization was the least important (M=2.94) variable of all.

4.4 Regression Analysis — Predictors of M-Commerce Purchase Frequency

A multiple regression analysis was conducted where the purchase frequency of m-commerce is the dependent variable while seven adoption determinants serve as independent variables. Results of the analysis have revealed that the regression model has been statistically significant ($F(7, 390) = 42.87, p < 0.001$) with the coefficient of determination of 0.612.

Table 4: Multiple Regression Results — Predictors of M-Commerce Purchase Frequency

Predictor Variable	Beta (β)	t-value	p-value	Significance
Perceived Usefulness	0.341	8.24	< 0.001	***
Ease of Mobile Payment	0.298	7.11	< 0.001	***
Trust and Security	0.224	5.62	< 0.001	***
Personalisation Quality	0.187	4.43	< 0.001	***
Delivery Speed	0.163	3.98	< 0.001	***

Predictor Variable	Beta (β)	t-value	p-value	Significance
Social Influence	0.119	2.87	0.004	**
App Interface Quality	0.098	2.31	0.021	*

Note: *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$

The usefulness of the service ($\beta = 0.341$) and ease of mobile payments ($\beta = 0.298$) were the most important factors identified by the regression analysis, thus validating the applicability of the TAM model to predict purchase behavior within m-commerce. The next most important factor was trust and security ($\beta = 0.224$), which highlights the importance of consumer trust as an important motivator for frequent purchases. Social influence ($\beta = 0.119$) and the design of the application interface ($\beta = 0.098$) had less significant impacts on purchase decisions.

4.5 Barriers to M-Commerce Adoption

The participants who were either hesitant or did not adopt mobile commerce ($n = 42$) gave reasons for non-adoption as follows (in order of prevalence): security of payment information (76.2%), weak internet connection (61.9%), inability to examine the product (52.4%), complicated process of returning goods (42.9%), and distrust towards online retailers (38.1%). The results resonate well with existing literature on the barriers to m-commerce (Yeh, 2020; GSMA, 2023).

4.6 Impact on E-Retailer Operations — Secondary Data Analysis

Analysis of secondary data highlights that top Indian e-tailers are adopting a number of strategies as a response to growing m-commerce. The key operational changes that have taken place include:

- Mobile-exclusive promotions and flash deals to encourage customers to use their apps. Flipkart's Big Billion Days (2024) saw more than 85% orders coming from mobile applications.
- Constructions of micro-fulfilment centres: Amazon India's expansion of its network to over 60 cities made possible the delivery of goods on the same or next day within Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities.
- Implementation of personalization through AI: With its AI engine that generates 50 million+ data points every single day, Myntra provides personalized home pages to all active users, extending their session times by 34%.

- Incorporation of social commerce: Using WhatsApp and Facebook to support mobile-social commerce, Meesho achieved the success of reaching 130 million transacting customers.
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5. FINDINGS OF THE STUDY

From the integration of both primary data gathered through a survey of smartphone users and industry data, it can be observed that the following results were obtained:

Finding 1: M-Commerce Has Achieved Mainstream Adoption in Urban India

As evidenced by 87.4% of the total number of respondents who have made transactions via m-commerce in the last six months, and 47.2% of them doing the transaction at least once weekly, m-commerce has successfully become the primary medium of digital retail engagement for Indians ages 18-45 residing in urban areas.

Finding 2: Mobile Payment Infrastructure Is a Critical Enabler

The success of UPI as a payment rail that enables instant and free payments has had a profound impact on the m-commerce adoption process in India. The ease of making payments using mobile devices ($\beta = 0.298$, $p < 0.001$) is the second most important determinant of purchase frequency, and a whopping 89.2% of respondents said that they make payments through UPI as a part of their regular m-commerce transactions.

Finding 3: Trust Remains a Significant Determinant

In spite of its wide adoption, security and trust issues still present a serious challenge to many consumers and act as a moderating factor for those who have adopted it. The third most important predictor of purchase frequency is trust ($\beta = 0.224$, $p < 0.001$), while 76.2% of the non-adoption group attribute security issues as the main reason for not adopting e-retailing.

Finding 4: Personalisation Is a Competitive Differentiator

AI-powered personalization can greatly boost the effectiveness of mobile commerce and purchase rates. Customers reporting high satisfaction with personalized recommendations showed twice as many purchases compared to dissatisfied respondents. The results imply that AI and machine learning development is an area that warrants significant investment from e-tailers.

Finding 5: M-Commerce Is Reshaping E-Retailer Business Models

Secondary research indicates that the rising importance of m-commerce has compelled e-retailers to embrace mobile-first product design, application-based user interaction, and hyperlocal delivery systems. The omnichannel model, which utilizes mobile devices to manage customer interactions across both the physical and virtual worlds, is gradually becoming the preferred retail system design for e-retailers.

Finding 6: The Digital Divide Remains a Structural Challenge

Urban areas have seen good levels of acceptance of m-commerce; however, rural areas in India suffer from inadequate connectivity. A mere 38 percent of the rural population sampled (n=64) use m-commerce on a consistent basis, with the reasons being lack of connectivity (72 percent), lack of digital awareness (58 percent), and lack of last mile connectivity (48 percent).

Finding 7: Social Commerce Is an Emerging High-Growth Segment

Social commerce is currently booming, especially when integrated into platforms that include WhatsApp, Instagram, and Facebook. It is worth noting that this trend is more common among younger customers (the 18-25 year-old demographic). In this demographic, 61.4 percent stated that they discovered products on social media and purchased the same within the last three months.

6. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

6.1 Conclusion

This research paper has provided an empirical investigation into the rise of mobile commerce and its effect on e-commerce in India, considering the global trend toward mobile commerce. It has been found that m-commerce is more than just the evolution of e-commerce; it is a unique concept altogether that influences the way consumers behave, compete among themselves, and conduct their business.

It is evident from the quick adoption of smartphones, the revolutionary effect of UPI, the democratization of social commerce, and the competitive edge offered by AI-driven personalization that there has been the emergence of a new era, where mobile is the key point of contact for all retail transactions. For any e-retailer to succeed in this era, it is imperative to adopt a mobile-first mindset in all aspects of business operations.

On the other hand, the findings of this research point out that the expansion of m-commerce should also take into account inclusiveness for sustainability purposes. Digital divide, security threats, and regulation issues are some of the hurdles that must be overcome through collective efforts of the government, businesses, and international agencies. India is one country where such lessons can be learned, based on its fast adoption, payments, and innovative business strategies.

The main contribution of this research paper to theory involves the examination and expansion of the TAM model for the Indian m-commerce setting, which includes trust, payment convenience, personalization, and social factors as important variables. Meanwhile, the practical contributions of this paper include recommendations for e-retailers and regulators.

6.2 Limitations

There are various limitations associated with the current study. Firstly, the sample population is confined only to four cities within India, making the results ungeneralizable to other rural or semi-urban areas. Secondly, it is possible that the results collected using survey questionnaires are biased due to social desirability. Lastly, since the current study uses cross-sectional research design, no causal conclusions can be drawn.

6.3 Future Scope

A few research opportunities worth pursuing in the future include the following:

- 1. Augmented Reality (AR) Shopping:** With the widespread adoption of advanced AR features such as virtual fitting rooms and 3D product imagery, future research must focus on their effects on customer trust, return policies, and buying decisions.
- 2. Voice Shopping:** Voice commerce is becoming increasingly common as users use voice assistants like Siri, Google Assistant, and Alexa for shopping purposes, warranting further scrutiny in terms of inclusivity and innovative interactions.
- 3. Mobile E-Commerce Sustainability:** There is an increasing interest in the eco-friendliness of mobile commerce, specifically the effects of packaging and carbon emissions from last-mile deliveries.
- 4. Socio-cultural Analysis Across Nations:** Comparing mobile e-commerce adoption and implications among BRICS countries or ASEAN member states is a fruitful avenue for future research.

5. Conversational Mobile E-Commerce with Large Language Models: The use of artificial intelligence to facilitate conversations, personalized styling, and intelligent customer service is a promising but largely unexplored topic.

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